

eg update

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【メール原文】

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iran

after the latest climbdown from president trump, more efforts to put a deal together. which looks a lot like the last deal, except this time with more explicit recognition of joint iranian/omani control over the strait of hormuz, without tolls but with "voluntary fees" for management of the waterway. it's being cobbled together by the regional players themselves—a direct negotiation between iran and oman, with the acceptance of the gulf countries. that accordingly makes the agreement more likely to be implemented...provided iran's leadership eventually agrees to terms and the united states is prepared to walk away from its war.

from iran's perspective the new agreement would be a compromise, since they had rejected previous such offers from the omanis. but it would also be a serious problem for trump and the united states, which will have essentially vested recognition of something that would have been completely unacceptable before the war. it's as if there was a ceasefire in ukraine and the united states recognized russian control over the occupied ukrainian territories (and if the americans had actually started the war, per misinformation from the kremlin...).

trump's problem (i'd call it a dilemma if he spent time analyzing it) is that what he considers an unacceptable outcome has also become unavoidable. there isn't a mechanism to reopen the strait by force, which most everyone else has, however reluctantly, come to realize. and that doesn't go away with this agreement: the iranians still see opportunity for more leverage, to get assets unfrozen, have sanctions removed, achieve a fund for reconstruction/war reparations...all the while continuing the push for tolls, and throwing maximalist demands out to spike the ball—including prohibiting transit through hormuz for the united states, israel, and "other hostile states;" and countries that have inflicted damage on iran not receiving transit permits until the damage is compensated. the latter are intended as throwaways, but will take time and process for an impatient trump administration to negotiate away "or else." while the united states intends to demand, at a minimum, concessions on iran's nuclear capabilities for any of that to happen.

so while the strait would open again if a deal is struck, with shipping picking up incrementally over the coming weeks, it's very likely to lead to more rounds of the iranians engaging in further strikes against ships and more proxy attacks in the region as well. it's also worth noting that a series of cyberattacks against american water facilities over the past days, only of nuisance value but symbolically important, both further show iranian resolve and display president trump's reluctance to engage in an escalatory cycle. taken together, this deal would be nearly as shaky/unstable as the previous memorandum of understanding. it might last a little longer, but ultimately the iranians have too many reasons to believe they should keep squeezing, use more leverage, and return to conflict.

thinking in our g-zero world

before i head out for a few weeks, i thought i'd spend a moment responding to a question i'm frequently asked: how can we process information in a world that moves so fast, in an overwhelming "news" environment that amounts to more noise than signal? it's something i think about a lot, especially when so many sources that we used to rely on have become polarized and harder to trust.

first, on news habits.

1) get your preferred ai model to act as a research assistant to create a short roundup (say 2000-word/10-minute read) of global news of the day, every morning. having first programmed it to know who you are/what your interests are, and explained why you think those things are important. i ensure it covers the most surprising, newsworthy, and counterintuitive pieces that it thinks i might miss from mainstream media in a few core areas (ai and emerging technologies, china politics and tech development, evolution of global security, global supply chains, across core geographies) and any wildcards that could change my existing worldview. ask follow-up questions when there's something that you find surprising.

2) curate a follow list (on substack, social media, and "irl" interactions) that includes a significant number of people that you respect intellectually, but fundamentally disagree with (or at least aren't aligned with) on core political issues. and make sure you're monitoring your own curated list, as opposed to "for you" feeds, which are programmed to confirm your preexisting biases and exploit your blind spots.

3) make a regular habit of digesting major global news that aren't from your country (especially if your country is the united states). 30 minutes of global coverage from nhk, deutsche welle, the cbc, or al jazeera is a useful way to see how news is prioritized and perceived that gets away from the relentless news cycle of domestic politics and clickbait. (corollary: don't spend time watching cable news from the "other side," whatever it is—that amounts to hate watching and only strengthens pre-existing views; better to just spend less time on cable).

4) take a break from the news cycle. leave most weekend/flight/vacation news time for long-form consumption, especially outside your area of expertise. one of the things i most value intellectually about my next few weeks is the ability to catch up on podcasts, books and real journalism (not to mention a few excellent novels). anyone can give you a credible two-minute soundbite on an issue; a credible in-depth discussion requires real expertise.

second, on analysis.

1) start with a mantra: analysis isn't about what you want, but about what actually is...and what is most likely to be. this should be obvious but it's surprising how often decisionmakers don't act that way. so much of my geopolitical perspective involves things that i'd really rather not be the case. but as ben shapiro writes, facts don't care about your feelings. i'd much rather if the g-zero world turned out to be wrong, not to mention most everything on where the present conflicts around russia/ukraine, iran, and us/china are presently heading. i'd be happier if president trump was successful more frequently. but none of those outcomes depend on our wishes and we can't be responsible for them.

2) be continually prepared to update your perspective. when big new developments occur, take time to think about what in the world becomes more and less likely as a consequence. after a major election. a new technological development. a war or a successful negotiation. given how fast the world changes,

one of the only things that's guaranteed is that even if our analysis is correct presently, it will become wrong if we don't revise it when the facts on the ground change. the political science model i first made a name for myself with back in 2006 was the j-curve, looking at the relationship between a country's openness and stability. it was predicated on technological developments (the communication revolution) that benefited open systems and undermined closed ones. when that technology shifted to the data/surveillance revolution, the j-curve no longer held...it's now a u. oh well. i spend an entire lecture with my columbia students on how the theory behind one of the books that they're reading no longer applies and why.

3) avoid false binary arguments. most outcomes are compromises, though they're rarely framed that way. when i'm asked a yes/no question, i'm happy to answer which way i'm leaning, but the answer is almost always more nuanced. i was at a meeting recently where the audience was asked who thought vice president vance would be the next republican nominee—only a very small number of people raised their hands...and predictably, one of the few that did then commented that the majority had their heads in the sand, and why vance was the favorite. but that wasn't the question—almost everyone in the room thought it was possible, but most recognized a lot of uncertainty some two years before the decision was at hand. and relatedly...

4) make estimates of likelihood. that's important less because the percentage is accurate, and more because it gives attention to the prospect of the thing you don't expect to happen actually happening. saying "i believe x will happen" is akin to a crystal ball that you don't have. more analytically robust is "i think x is 70% likely for the following reasons," and then think through how the 30% could come about. and how it could become more likely.

5) regularly look back to previous assessments. our most important analytic piece of work is our top risks report—and the most important part of that work is the year-end retrospective, before we publish the new one, when we go back to see (and then write about) the accuracy of the calls from twelve months ago. and relatedly...

6) learn from analytic mistakes. when javier milei was elected president in argentina, i expected he was going to fail. in part because the economic challenges in argentina were daunting (it's like betting that israeli-palestinian negotiations won't amount to much, what you'd call a politically safe bet), but in part because his campaign platform—de-dollarization, shuttering the central bank, and a number of other promises—were so outlandish. the former was a fair point, the latter proved wrong when he quickly pivoted to pragmatism, and was rewarded by the markets, the imf, the united states and others accordingly. but why had i gotten that wrong? why the assumption that he was going ahead with such a platform? because he was a complete political outsider and, unlike with many other leaders, i didn't have access to close advisors or senior officials who had worked with him, who could tell me that this campaign rhetoric was mostly politics to ensure a win. that was a blind spot—and showed that i needed to be much less quick to judge in other cases of political outsiders where i couldn't necessarily rely on a trusted network.

7) recognize when things aren't knowable—and why they aren't knowable. frequently there will be critical information that determines an outcome that isn't available at the time of the assessment. isolating that information, assessing its importance, and calling out the indeterminacy of the outcome is an important thing to do. and those are donald rumsfeld's proverbial known unknowns; there are also, of course, unknown unknowns whose importance we can't assess by definition...but whose existence we should acknowledge as a matter of epistemic humility.

8) accept that longer timeframes are getting harder to assess. that's not true for everything—demographics remain sticky and pretty easy to project...with important outcomes (for consumption, employment, pensions and healthcare). but it's become much truer for geopolitics—there's more macro uncertainty in a global order than isn't stable/sustainable. and it's even more true because an essential determinant of outcomes, our present ai/technology revolution, is structural and faster-moving than any macro/structural variable we've ever encountered. having more room for what would normally be truly unexpected outcomes becomes essential.

and start your week with the eg update. but that should go without saying :)

russia

i've been most concerned geopolitically about fat-tailed risks coming from russian president putin, failing mightily in his war in ukraine and domestically unconstrained from escalation. and now we appear to see an explosive drone attack that displays a dramatic increase in putin's willingness to take the war directly to a nato country.

the drones, one loaded with semtex, the other apparently intended to take video of the expected explosion, were placed on the tarmac of germany's leipzig airport—one of the main transit and logistic points for ammunition and related defense support going on to ukraine. and also notably, the same airport where russia attempted to blow up a dhl plane in 2024 with a parcel package. hard to imagine a german lone wolf attack both incented to make such a strike and capable of pulling it off; even harder to see the ukrainians risking their relationship with germany in a false-flag effort to further unite europe against the russians (and hardly necessary given where european concerns are heading).

combined with 1) the highest level of intensity of russian ballistic missile attacks against kyiv that we've seen since the beginning of the war and 2) a north korean ballistic missile unit—soldiers alongside some 120 missiles and 6 launchers—apparently being deployed to russia in support of the war, we're seeing a steady and increasingly sharp focus on russian military expansion against ukraine and the countries directly supporting it.

as worryingly, there remains no credible american or european military response against these russian escalations into nato countries. the polish government has been raising the idea of helping ukraine shoot down russian missiles over its territory, but there's no broader support for it; most nato governments are deeply concerned about taking actions that would lead the russians to respond directly against them as a consequence. but as leon trotsky once said, "you may not be interested in war, but war is interested in you."

india

and a challenge for the strongest leader of any major democracy, indian prime minister narendra modi. a series of missteps by his education minister has played into a group that's upset with their opportunities (and hardly unique to the subcontinent)...india's youth. they created a protest movement, the cockroach janata party (after being told young people were like cockroaches—think deplorables embracing their supposed humiliation in the united states), and the government's initial response was what it has typically been in these situations: no compromise and a heavy hand. which quickly got out of control—demonstrations of tens of thousands in delhi and then urban centers across the country—with the youth showing they weren't going to give up so easily.

losing the public narrative, modi ended up backing down, forced to remove his education minister. the youth, who coalesced specifically around that issue, quickly dispersed. but this is an important challenge

to india's prime minister, who back in the 2019 national elections had a significant advantage among younger voters...but no longer. and it's going to persist...especially around questions of civil society, the media, censorship and, most importantly, opportunity and unemployment (with some 30% of india's college graduates numbering among the jobless) from a government that they increasingly believe doesn't care about or adequately represent them. modi's party just lost a by-election in bihar (to a relatively little-known anti-corruption party on the left), and this is likely to grow over the coming year, with anti-incumbency trends rising across five states including uttar pradesh (india's most populous), where state elections will be held next february-march. worth watching in a world where anti-establishment trends are only growing and india now—especially from the perspective of generation z which knows nothing else—has a new, quite powerful, political establishment. and that's likely to kick off a debate over what comes after modi, which should begin in earnest in the coming year.

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i'm in nantucket where i'll be until labor day—a combination of frenetic activity and low stress with a house full of my favorite people. for the next four weeks, guest updates with some fascinating thinking from analysts i know and love. hope you manage some enjoyable downtime too...

with very best wishes and back with you soon.

yours,

ian

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